



SAINT PIERRE
LEARNING RESOURCES

READING

Theme Detectives

Evidence in Original Fiction

Grade 5 • Florida

INSIDE THIS RESOURCE

Teacher guide and student practice

Assessment and answer key

Differentiation and accessibility supports

PRINTABLE PDF | SINGLE-TEACHER LICENSE

saintpierreresources.com



Teacher Guide

Level: Grade 5 • Florida

Standard / objective: ELA.5.R.1.2 — Explain the development of stated or implied theme(s) throughout a literary text.

Source / course note: Florida Department of Education B.E.S.T. ELA Standards:
<https://www.fldoe.org/core/fileparse.php/7539/urlt/elabeststandardsfinal.pdf>

Before this lesson: Identify characters, a problem, and the sequence of events.

Model and discuss: Contrast a topic (teamwork) with a theme (accepting help can turn a setback into progress). Trace Mina restarting, accepting paint, and sharing the finished sign.

Watch for: A theme is not a one-word topic or a plot summary. Require a general lesson and evidence from more than one part of the story.

Suggested sequence: 5-minute launch, 10-minute model, 20-30 minutes of practice, then a 5-minute exit ticket. Use separate paper for extended writing.

Learning supports

AIG: Defend a second plausible theme using different evidence from the same text.

504: Offer chunked tasks, reduced copying, extra time, and breaks as specified in the learner's plan.

EC: Use a three-box beginning/middle/end organizer and rehearse the explanation aloud.

ESL: Rehearse: At first _____. Later _____. By the end _____. These changes suggest _____.

Adapt these suggestions to the current learning plan. Print on US Letter paper at actual size; keep the key separate. One teacher may use the resource with their own students; no public posting or resale.

The Garden Sign

Mina had promised to paint the welcome sign for the community garden. On Friday afternoon, she brushed green letters across a smooth board: EVERYONE CAN GROW HERE. She added tiny yellow flowers around the edge. The garden would open the next morning, and Mina wanted her sign to be the first thing visitors saw.

She left the board outside while she went in to wash her brushes. A sudden shower rattled the windows. By the time she reached the porch, rain had dragged green paint down the board. The letters looked like tall weeds. Mina pressed her lips together. She had used nearly all her paint.

For a moment, she imagined telling the neighbors that the sign was impossible. Instead, she carried the board inside, dried it with an old towel, and set it near the open window. When the wood was dry, she sanded the smeared letters and drew new pencil lines. Starting again did not feel exciting. It felt slow.

Mr. Ortiz stopped by with garden stakes and noticed the board. He offered blue paint left from his fence. Mina almost refused. She wanted to finish the sign herself. Then she looked at her nearly empty jars and asked whether they could use his paint for the background.

Soon Leila brought white paint, and two younger neighbors offered to fill in the flowers. Mina showed them how to wipe extra paint from their brushes. One flower turned into a large, uneven circle. Instead of covering it, Mina added a stem and made it the tallest blossom. The neighbors laughed and kept working.

On Saturday morning, they carried the dry sign to the gate together. Its flowers were different sizes, and its blue background was not what Mina had planned. But the words were clear. When the first family arrived, a little boy read them aloud. Mina smiled at her neighbors. The sign did more than welcome people to the garden. It showed how the garden had begun.

Original fiction written for this resource. Use details from the beginning, middle, and ending to explain how a theme develops.



Student Directions & Practice

Read an original story about a student repairing a community garden sign; trace how choices and consequences develop a theme.

Directions: Complete every item. Show work or cite evidence. For open responses, answer in complete sentences.

- 1.** What challenge does Mina face?

- 2.** Which action first suggests persistence?

- 3.** State one possible theme.

- 4.** Give two details that develop that theme.

- 5.** How does the ending strengthen the theme?

- 6.** Which detail would weaken the theme if removed? Explain.

- 7.** Write a four-sentence objective summary.

- 8.** Write a new ending that preserves the theme.



Assessment / Exit Ticket

Work independently. Show your reasoning. Use extra paper if needed.

1. State a theme of The Garden Sign as a complete sentence.

2. Explain how an early event and the ending develop that theme.

Reflection: What helped you decide? What do you want to practice next?

Score each task: 2 = accurate with clear reasoning; 1 = partly correct or missing reasoning; 0 = incorrect or no evidence. The reflection is not scored.

Answer Key & Teaching Guidance

1. The rain ruins Mina's painted sign before the garden opening.
2. She dries the board and begins again instead of quitting.
3. Possible: steady effort and accepting help can overcome setbacks.
4. She restarts after the rain; she accepts neighbors' spare paint and help.
5. The completed sign represents shared effort and resilience.
6. Reasoned responses using a relevant story detail.
7. Summary should include challenge, response, help, and outcome without opinion.
8. Answers vary but must show the same theme.

Exit ticket guidance

1. Possible: Accepting help while persisting through setbacks can lead to shared success. Other defensible themes are acceptable.
2. For example, Mina first tries to repair the sign alone, then accepts neighbors' materials and help; carrying it together at the end shows her change. Credit accurate evidence and an explicit connection.

Next teaching move: Use the worked model again if the concept is unclear. If the answer is correct but reasoning is incomplete, ask for an explanation. Offer the extension once both tasks are secure. Scores guide instruction; they are not standardized mastery cutoffs.